THE SHATTERED GATE

Chapter Two — The Gate Screams

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By the time the squad reached the courtyard, the city had stopped pretending.

People stood three deep around the edge of the great round yard. They hadn't been told to come. Nobody had rung anything. They had simply put down whatever they were holding and walked here, the way people walk towards smoke — bakers with flour to the elbow, a tanner still in his apron, two old women from the lantern-wick stalls holding hands like girls. Nobody stepped onto the flagstones. There was a ring of bare stone thirty paces wide around the Gate, and every soul in Emberhold had kept to the outside of it since before most of them were born.

Inside the ring stood the Gate, and the morning light went around it wrong.

Kaelren saw that first, before anything else. The sun was up over the east wall now and threw long shadows west across the yard —

every post, every barrel, every person had a shadow leaning the same way. The Gate's shadow leaned towards the sun.

"Oh, I don't like that," Bren said, at his shoulder. "I don't like that at all."

"Nobody likes it," Lysa said. "Stand up straight, they're looking at us."

They were. The Emberguard had thrown a loose cordon round the bare ring — nine or ten soldiers with spears, most of them recruits Kaelren had watched miss targets all spring. They had the faces of boys who had been told to guard a thing and had only just realised they didn't know what it would do. When the squad came through the crowd a few of them sagged with relief, as if five more people made the arch less likely to eat them.

The nearest of them was Dalen, who was nineteen and had asked Kaelren twice that month how you got the crust right on the black-seed loaves, and had not believed the answer either time. He had his spear in both hands, crosswise, like a man holding a gate shut.

"Sir," he said. "It's — sir, it's doing it again."

"I know."

"Captain said hold the ring."

"Then hold it." Kaelren put a hand on his shoulder going past and felt the boy shaking through the mail. "Feet wider. You'll stand longer."

Dalen moved his feet. It was something to do.

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The Gate hummed.

It was louder down here, the note he'd felt through the wall. Not loud the way a bell is loud. Loud the way a held breath is loud when you're the one holding it. It came up through his boots and settled behind his breastbone, and he could see by Talla's face that she was getting it worse. She had both palms flat against the courtyard wall behind her, the old way her mother's people listened to stone, and her lips were moving.

"Talla."

"They're all saying the same thing." She didn't open her eyes. "All the stones. Every one. They've never — Kaelren, they've never agreed on anything. There's a stone by the well that's been angry about a wedding for two hundred years. They're all saying the same thing."

"What thing?"

She opened her eyes. They were wet. "*Here.*"

Sev, beside her, had stopped shuffling his cards. That was how Kaelren knew it was bad. He had never once, in the two years Sev had served with them, seen the cards stop. Sev was Shadowdeep born, out of the tunnels under a city that didn't exist any more, and he had told Kaelren once, drunk, that Shadowdeep children were taught to keep their hands busy so nobody would see them think. His hands were still now. He was looking at the Gate the way a man looks at a cliff edge in the dark.

"Captain," Sev said softly. Meaning Kaelren. Sev always called him captain when he was frightened, and never otherwise.

"I know."

"No, you don't." Sev wet his lips. "Where I come from, we had a word for when the light goes the wrong way round a thing. We said it

was being *read*."

The keystone lit.

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It didn't flicker this time. It came on the way a forge comes on when the bellows catch — a pulse, then a heave, then light running down both sides of the arch at once, filling the old carved runes like water filling a ditch. The colours came one after another, so fast they piled on each other. Red. Blue-black. A hard white gold that hurt to look at. A grey like snow light. Silver.

All the dead Realms. Every one of them, in order, the way they had gone out. Kaelren had watched each of those lights die over three hundred years, and now the Gate was showing him their funeral again, in order.

He found he was counting them under his breath, as you name the dead at dusk.

The crowd made a sound — one sound, a whole city drawing in at once.

Inside the arch, the air stopped being air.

He would never be able to tell anyone what he saw there, not properly, and in years to come he would stop trying. It was like looking down into deep water and seeing a whole drowned world at the bottom, except the water was standing upright in a stone frame and the world kept changing. A sky of molten gold, and towers under it with no shadows at all. A forest of black trees, all of them listening. A fortress hung on chains of lightning over a gulf with no bottom. A

river of fire running under a city, and the city's windows lit from below. Lanterns on dark water, hundreds of them, drifting in mist.

Then, under all of them, something that was not a Realm. Something wide and patient and grey, like the inside of a closed eye.

The Gate screamed.

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It was not a sound. That was what he understood afterwards, lying awake. The cordon dropped their spears and the crowd put their hands over their ears and the braziers along the yard went out all together like a row of blown candles, but none of that was because of noise. It was the feeling you get when someone forgets your name to your face — that small cold drop — except all at once, in every person, from the inside, as if the world had tried to forget them all and failed by a hair.

The flagstones cracked in a ring around the arch. Ghostlight bled up out of the cracks, pale and sick, and drifted upward like ash off a fire.

And something came through.

It came fast, and it came falling, though the Gate stood upright and there was nowhere to fall from. A shape tumbling end over end out of the drowned lights, wrapped in a tail of something that was half fire and half shadow, like a comet seen through smoked glass. It cleared the arch, came down onto the courtyard stone thirty paces from Kaelren, and hit so hard the ground jumped.

He was on one knee before he knew it. Beside him Bren had gone flat on his back and Lysa was on her side with an arrow already on

the string and no idea where to point it. Dust rolled out across the yard in a low wave and broke against the crowd.

Then it was quiet. The real, ordinary kind of quiet. A dog barking blocks away. Someone in the crowd being sick.

The Gate stood dark again. Its shadow, Kaelren saw, leaned west with all the others.

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"Is it—" Bren said, sitting up. He was white to the lips. "Kaelren, is that a man?"

It was a man.

He lay at the bottom of a shallow crater he'd made in the flagstones, on his back, one arm thrown out. His clothes, whatever they had been, were mostly burned away; what was left looked older than anything in Emberhold, a weave Kaelren didn't know. His skin was grey with ash. Under the ash, all over him — down his arms, across his chest, up the side of his throat — ran lines of light. Runes, or something like runes, cut into him like the carvings in the arch, and they were moving: brightening and dimming out of step with each other, like the lights of a city where nobody can agree when to go to bed.

He was breathing. Barely. Kaelren could see his chest catch, stop, catch again.

"Nobody touches him," Kaelren said. He stood up. His knee hurt, which it shouldn't have, and he put that away to think about later. "Bren, get Mareth. Run. Sev, the cordon — get them back on their

feet and get the crowd pushed back another ten paces. Lysa, eyes on the Gate. If it so much as hums, you shout."

"And do what?"

"Shout louder."

Nobody laughed. But they moved, which was what he'd wanted. Bren went through the crowd like a bull through a hedge. Sev's voice rose behind him, sharp and calm, the voice he used when he'd decided to be someone braver than he felt.

Talla had not moved from the wall. She was staring at the man in the crater.

"The stones stopped," she said. "Kaelren. They've all gone quiet."

He walked down into the crater.

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Up close the man looked young, and then he didn't. It changed while Kaelren watched, the way a face changes in firelight — one moment a man of thirty, the next something with a great deal more behind it, tired the way old mountains look tired. His hair was dark and full of ash. His hands were scarred across the backs with marks Kaelren didn't know, a writing that wasn't any of the nine.

The light under his skin was going out.

Kaelren crouched beside him. He didn't touch him. He had been alive long enough to have a healthy respect for things that fell out of the sky.

The man's eyes opened.

They glowed. Not with light — the yard was bright, and there was nothing for light to do in them. They glowed the way a

remembered thing glows in your mind when you haven't thought of it in years, a face from childhood, a room you used to sleep in. They were full of something. They were looking straight up past Kaelren at the open sky, wide and wet and searching, and the man's lips moved.

He said a word.

Kaelren didn't know the language. Nobody in Emberhold would. He was sure of that in the way you are sure of the cold. But the word went into him anyway, under the ribs, the place the Gate's hum had sat, and something there rang back at it like a struck glass. He didn't understand it. He felt it. It felt like being called by name in a crowd by someone you can't see.

The man's hand came up. It shook. It reached past Kaelren's face towards the empty air, fingers spread, as if there was someone standing there — someone tall, to judge by the angle — and he was reaching for someone and could not quite close the distance.

Then the hand fell. The eyes closed. The runes under his skin pulsed once, together for the first time, and went dark.

He was still breathing.

Kaelren looked down at his face, and the world went out from under him.

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He knew it.

Not the way you know a stranger looks like someone. He knew it the way he knew the burn on his palm. He knew the long jaw and the line between the brows and the way the mouth sat, even unconscious,

as if it had been about to say something mild and had thought better of it. He knew it from a courtyard eleven hundred years and four thousand miles away, a pale stone courtyard with autumn light coming in at a low angle. He had been seventeen. He had been walking beside a boy who didn't like to be looked at, and a man in Council grey had crossed the yard towards them on his way somewhere else.

The man had not been looking at them. Then, just for a moment, he had.

He'd looked at the boy beside Kaelren as if he'd almost remembered something. Two seconds. The way you look at a word on the tip of your tongue. Then he'd gone on through the west door and was gone, and the boy beside Kaelren had stood in the middle of the courtyard for a long time afterwards, not moving, and had never once in Kaelren's hearing talked about it.

They had called that man a lot of things, back then. The Councillor without a Realm. The Hammer-Bearer. Most people, because it was easiest, had just called him the Voyager.

He had disappeared a thousand years ago. Everyone knew that story, the way everyone knows stories they've stopped believing. He had gone to end the war, and the war had swallowed him, and nobody had ever seen him again.

Kaelren had. Kaelren was looking at him.

He found that he had put his right hand flat on the stone beside the man's head, without meaning to, the way you'd put a hand on a sleeping child. The burn on his palm was warm again. Not as warm as before. Warmer than it had been on the wall.

"Well," he said, very quietly, to nobody. "Well. There you are."

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Mareth came down the steps on Bren's arm, swearing at every one of them. She was out of breath and furious about it. She took one look at the man in the crater and stopped swearing, which frightened Bren more than anything else that morning, and lowered herself onto her knees in the ash with a crack of joints.

She put two fingers to the man's throat. She put her palm flat on his chest. She lifted one eyelid with her thumb and looked for a long moment at what was underneath.

"Alive," she said. "I've no idea why." She looked up at Kaelren over the man's body, and he saw her see it in his face — whatever there was in his face — and saw her decide, as she had decided once before with a needle in her hand, not to ask in front of anyone.

"Can you move him?"

"I can tell Bren to move him." She sat back on her heels. "Gently, Bren. Like he's made of eggs. Like he's made of *my* eggs."

Bren picked the man up the way Kaelren had seen him pick up lambs at the ash-farms, both arms under, careful of the head. The man weighed nothing in his arms. Ash sifted off him and fell like flour.

There was a stir at the top of the courtyard and the crowd parted, and Captain Thalen came down through it at a run with half the day watch behind him. He was a square, grizzled man in his fifties who had been in command of Emberhold's walls for eleven years and looked every one of them this morning. He had his sword out. He took in the dark Gate, the cracked ring, the burned man in Bren's arms, the cordon, the crowd — took it all in at a glance like a man

reading a battlefield — and then his eyes came to Kaelren and stayed there.

"Report."

"The Gate opened. That came through." Kaelren nodded at Bren's burden. "Alive. Mareth's taking him."

"*Came through.*" Thalen stared at the arch. "From where? There's nothing left out there. There's nothing to come from."

"Apparently there is."

Thalen looked at the stranger for a long time. Kaelren watched him do it. Thalen was a good officer, the best Emberhold had had in Thalen's lifetime and probably the one before. He was honest the way a hammer is honest, and he had buried his own brother on the north wall seven winters ago without a word to anyone, and Kaelren trusted him as much as he trusted anyone alive.

"Do you know him?" Thalen said.

The question came out plain and quiet, one soldier to another. It wasn't an accusation. Thalen asked it because Kaelren had been on this wall longer than anyone, and when strange things happened, people asked Kaelren.

Behind Thalen, Mareth had gone still on the steps.

Kaelren thought about the courtyard. The autumn light. The boy beside him. He thought about what would happen in this city, in the next hour, if he said *yes* — if he said, *that is the Voyager, who sat on the Aetherguard Council when the Nine Realms were whole, and the last time I saw him I was a boy, and I am eleven hundred years old, and so, Captain, are my reasons for keeping my mouth shut.* He thought about the High Councillor hearing it. He thought about the word *Void*, and how fast it travelled in a frightened city.

He looked Thalen in the eye.

"No," he said. "Never seen him in my life."

Thalen held his gaze a moment longer, then nodded once and turned away to bark at the cordon.

It was the first lie Kaelren had ever told him.

He stood in the cracked courtyard with the warm scar in his closed fist and listened to the city start to talk, and knew it wouldn't be the last.

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End of Chapter Two